

PERSONAL READING SERIES

AT THE EDGES OF CHRISTIANITY

*Jehovah's Witnesses, Unitarian Universalism,
the New Apostolic Reformation, Unity, and the Word of Faith*

*Some claim the Christian label.
Some have moved beyond it entirely.
All of them represent something Christianity produced
when it pushed its own logic to an extreme —
or when people needed something it could not provide.*

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INTRODUCTION

When Christianity Reaches Its Edges

Every tradition, pushed to its logical extreme, produces something its center would not recognize. Christianity has produced at its edges: a movement that claims God's true name and door-to-door evangelism as a religious obligation (Jehovah's Witnesses), a tradition that abandoned creed entirely in favor of a free search for truth (Unitarian Universalism), a movement that believes God is restoring the apostolic and prophetic offices to drive demons from entire geographic territories (New Apostolic Reformation), communities that brought New Thought directly into Sunday morning church format (Unity, Religious Science), and a global movement that teaches that faith and spoken declarations produce financial wealth as evidence of divine favor (Word of Faith / Prosperity Gospel).

Each of these represents a specific response to something the mainstream churches could not provide — whether that is doctrinal certainty, theological freedom, direct felt power, practical manifestation tools, or community belonging. The Haligric practitioner reads each tradition with precision and compassion: what did this tradition correctly identify? What did it do with what it found? And where did the mechanism — which was real — get distorted by the framework placed around it?

JEHOVAH'S WITNESSES

The Complete Picture

Jehovah's Witnesses are among the most studied, most misrepresented, and most misunderstood religious communities in the world. The Haligric approach is to examine them with the same precision and respect applied to every other tradition in this library — not to dismiss them and not to excuse what deserves examination.

ORIGINS — Charles Taze Russell and the Millerite Legacy

Founded: 1870s Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania

Charles Taze Russell was born in 1852 in Pittsburgh to Presbyterian parents. He became deeply troubled by the doctrine of eternal hell in his teens — finding it theologically incompatible with a God of love — and began studying scripture independently, eventually connecting with Adventist groups whose biblical chronology predicted the imminent return of Christ.

Russell predicted Christ's invisible return in 1874 and the visible establishment of God's Kingdom on earth in 1914. When 1914 arrived without the expected visible kingdom, the interpretation shifted — 1914 became the year Christ began ruling invisibly in heaven, with the end of the present world system imminent. Date predictions were subsequently made for 1925 and 1975, both passing without the expected Armageddon. The organization's response to failed predictions has consistently been reinterpretation rather than acknowledgment of error.

After Russell's death in 1916, Joseph Franklin Rutherford ('Judge Rutherford') took control of the Watch Tower Society and significantly tightened organizational structure, centralized authority, introduced the name Jehovah's Witnesses in 1931, and developed many of the distinctive practices that characterize the movement today.

❖ **HALIGRIC LENS: Russell's initial theological instinct — that eternal hell is incompatible with divine love — was correct and is shared by Haligricity. The problem was not the instinct but what was built around it: a centralized authority structure that replaced the Pope's infallibility with the Watch Tower Society's organizational infallibility, achieving the same result through different means.**

THEOLOGY — What Witnesses Actually Believe

Witness theology diverges from mainstream Christianity at several critical points. Jehovah — the personal name of God as rendered in their New World Translation of the Bible — is the only true God. Jesus Christ is not God but the first and greatest of Jehovah's creations — identified with the Archangel Michael in his pre-human existence, exalted to a divine position after his resurrection but never equal to Jehovah. The Holy Spirit is not a person but Jehovah's active force — his power at work in the world.

The 144,000 mentioned in the Book of Revelation are the anointed class — the relatively small group who will rule with Christ in heaven. The vast majority of Witnesses belong to the 'great crowd' — the other sheep who will survive Armageddon and live in paradise on a restored earth under Christ's heavenly government. This earthly hope is the primary motivating vision for most Witnesses.

Blood transfusions are prohibited based on the scriptural commands not to eat blood (Genesis 9:4, Acts 15:28-29) — interpreted as prohibiting the introduction of blood from another person into one's own body. This doctrine has resulted in deaths, including children whose parents refused transfusions on their behalf, and has generated significant legal and ethical controversy globally.

Birthdays are not celebrated — associated with pagan practices and the context of two biblical birthday references (both resulting in executions). Christmas, Easter, Halloween, and other holidays are not celebrated — their pagan origins understood as disqualifying them from Christian observance regardless of their current cultural meaning.

THE WATCH TOWER SOCIETY — How Authority Works

The Watch Tower Bible and Tract Society is the legal and organizational entity through which Jehovah's Witnesses operate globally. The Governing Body — a small group of men at the organization's headquarters (currently in Warwick, New York) — is understood as the Faithful and Discreet Slave of Matthew 24:45: the class appointed by God to provide spiritual food at the proper time. Their interpretations of scripture are understood as directed by Jehovah's spirit and are binding on all Witnesses worldwide.

The organizational structure flows from the Governing Body through Branch Committees in each country, to Circuit Overseers who oversee groups of congregations, to Congregation Elders (unpaid lay men appointed by the organization) who manage each local congregation. There is no professional clergy. All Witnesses are expected to participate in the door-to-door ministry — monthly reporting of field service hours is submitted to the congregation and reviewed.

All publications — The Watchtower, Awake!, and a comprehensive library of books and study materials — are produced by the Watch Tower Society and are used as the primary study materials in all Witness gatherings.

Independent study of other religious materials, or forming conclusions that differ from Watch Tower publications, is strongly discouraged and can result in disciplinary action.

❖ **HALIGRIC LENS:** The Watch Tower Society achieved what every institutional religion attempts: the complete routing of all spiritual authority through a single organizational channel. The Governing Body's interpretations cannot be questioned any more than papal pronouncements could be questioned in pre-Reformation Catholicism. The result is a community of extraordinary dedication and extraordinary docility — people who have surrendered their own spiritual authority completely to an organization that claims to speak for God. This is the institutional form of the dynamic that Haligrity identifies as the central wound of Western religion.

DISFELLOWSHIPPING AND SHUNNING

Disfellowshipping is the formal exclusion of a Witness from the community for violations of Witness doctrine or morality. The announcement in the congregation is simply: '[Name] is no longer one of Jehovah's Witnesses.' No reason is given publicly. The consequence is complete shunning: other Witnesses — including immediate family members who are still Witnesses — are instructed not to associate with the disfellowshipped person, not to eat with them, not to greet them. The only exception is necessary family business.

The shunning practice is one of the most psychologically devastating aspects of the Witness community for those who leave or are expelled. Former members consistently describe losing all their social relationships simultaneously — friends, family, community — at the moment of disfellowshipping. For people who grew up in the organization, whose entire social world exists within it, this is experienced as a form of social death.

The reinstating process — which involves written letters of repentance, a period of demonstrated changed behavior, and a Judicial Committee review — typically takes months to years. Former members describe the reinstatement process as designed to be difficult enough to deter leaving while remaining theoretically possible.

♦ **HALIGRIC LENS:** The shunning mechanism is precisely calibrated to make the cost of independent spiritual authority prohibitive. A person who concludes that the Watch Tower Society's teachings are not what they believed them to be faces a choice between continuing to live a life they no longer believe or losing everything. This is not a feature of the theology — it is a feature of the institutional control structure. The Haligric practitioner recognizes this structure without judgment toward individual Witnesses, the vast majority of whom are sincere, generous, and genuinely motivated by love for their community and their God.

LIFE AFTER THE WITNESSES

Former Jehovah's Witnesses represent one of the most studied groups of religious exiting in contemporary social science. The experience of leaving — whether by choice or disfellowshipping — is consistently described as one of the most disorienting experiences a person can undergo. Everything that was certain becomes uncertain simultaneously. Every relationship is affected. The skills for navigating a world outside the community — including basic social skills that the organization's insular culture did not develop — may be significantly underdeveloped.

Many former Witnesses experience a period of profound spiritual disorientation — not merely the loss of belief but the loss of an entire framework for understanding reality, meaning, and relationship. This disorientation, understood through the Haligric lens, is the dark night before the direct recognition: the moment when every externally-provided answer has been taken away and the person is left with the only thing that was always there — their own direct connection to the sacred, unmediated, uncontrolled, entirely their own.

♦ **HALIGRIC LENS:** The Haligric practitioner who encounters former Witnesses meets people in the most vulnerable and most potentially transformative moment of their spiritual lives. They have been through a form of death — the death of everything they knew. What comes next is either reconstruction of another external authority or the terrifying and liberating discovery that the authority was always within them. Haligrity is built for this moment.

UNITARIAN UNIVERSALISM

The Great Synthesis — Haligricity's Closest Institutional Ally

Of all the traditions covered in three Christianity documents, Unitarian Universalism stands apart. It is the only major religious institution that does not require a specific creed, that explicitly honors multiple religious sources as valid paths, and that centers the free search for truth as its theological foundation. It is the institutional form of the recognition that Haligricity holds — that no single tradition owns the truth, that the divine is accessible through many doors, and that the human being's own direct search is sacred.

THE HISTORY — From Servetus to the Present

Founded: 1961 CE (merger of American Unitarian Association and Universalist Church of America)

The Unitarian tradition traces to the 16th century Radical Reformation — specifically to the anti-Trinitarian movements that questioned whether the doctrine of the Trinity was scriptural. Michael Servetus, a Spanish physician and theologian, published works denying the Trinity in 1531 and 1553. He was burned at the stake in Geneva in 1553 — on the orders of John Calvin — as a heretic. He became a martyr figure for the anti-Trinitarian movement.

The Universalist tradition — the belief that all human beings will ultimately be saved, that a God of love cannot condemn any of his children to eternal punishment — emerged separately in America in the late 18th century, led by John Murray and Hosea Ballou. Universalism was the first denomination in America to ordain a woman (Olympia Brown, 1863).

The two traditions merged in 1961 to form the Unitarian Universalist Association. The merged tradition retained neither the anti-Trinitarian theology of the Unitarians (since many members were no longer Christian at all) nor the specifically Christian Universalism of the Universalists, but preserved both traditions' commitments to religious freedom, reason, and human dignity.

Key figures in the Unitarian tradition include Ralph Waldo Emerson (who resigned from his Unitarian pulpit in 1832 because even Unitarianism was too doctrinally constraining), Henry David Thoreau, and Susan B. Anthony. Joseph Priestley — who discovered oxygen — founded the first Unitarian congregation in America in 1796.

❖ **HALIGRIC LENS:** The Unitarian tradition produced the Transcendentalists — the American philosophical movement that first brought Vedantic non-dual philosophy into Western intellectual culture. Emerson's Oversoul, Thoreau's Walden practice, Whitman's cosmic democracy — all came from within the Unitarian stream. The tradition that burned Servetus for questioning the Trinity produced, three centuries later, the people who would introduce the Bhagavad Gita to American readers. The sacred moves through even its most hostile containers.

THE SEVEN UU PRINCIPLES

Adopted 1984-1985, reaffirmed and in process of revision

The seven UU Principles are the closest thing to a creed in Unitarian Universalism — though they are explicitly presented as aspirations, not required beliefs. They are affirmed and promoted by UU congregations:

FIRST PRINCIPLE: *The inherent worth and dignity of every person.*

SECOND PRINCIPLE: *Justice, equity, and compassion in human relations.*

THIRD PRINCIPLE: *Acceptance of one another and encouragement to spiritual growth.*

FOURTH PRINCIPLE: *A free and responsible search for truth and meaning.*

FIFTH PRINCIPLE: *The right of conscience and the use of the democratic process.*

SIXTH PRINCIPLE: *The goal of world community with peace, liberty, and justice for all.*

SEVENTH PRINCIPLE: *Respect for the interdependent web of all existence of which we are a part.*

♦ **HALIGRIC LENS:** The Fourth Principle — a free and responsible search for truth and meaning — is the most Haligric statement in any institutional religious document. It does not tell you what the truth is. It honors your search for it. The Seventh Principle — respect for the interdependent web of all existence of which we are a part — is the closest an institutional religious statement has come to expressing what Aboriginal Australians call Country, what Yoruba tradition calls Ashe, what Taoism calls the Tao. The web. The interconnection. The recognition that separateness is the illusion and relationship is the reality.

SIX SOURCES OF UU THEOLOGY

UU theology draws from six explicitly named sources — a level of formal multi-traditional honoring that is unique in institutional Western religion:

1. Direct experience of that transcending mystery and wonder, affirmed in all cultures, which moves us to a renewal of the spirit and an openness to the forces which create and uphold life.
2. Words and deeds of prophetic women and men which challenge us to confront powers and structures of evil with justice, compassion, and the transforming power of love.
3. Wisdom from the world's religions which inspires us in our ethical and spiritual life.
4. Jewish and Christian teachings which call us to respond to God's love by loving our neighbors as ourselves.
5. Humanist teachings which counsel us to heed the guidance of reason and the results of science, and warn us against idolatries of the mind and spirit.
6. Spiritual teachings of Earth-centered traditions which celebrate the sacred circle of life and instruct us in living in harmony with the rhythms of nature.

♦ **HALIGRIC LENS: Source Six — Earth-centered traditions — formally includes within UU theology the indigenous sacred traditions that every other mainstream Western religion spent centuries trying to eradicate. Source Three — wisdom from the world's religions — is the entire Haligrity library held as a valid source of truth. Unitarian Universalism did institutionally what Haligrity does as a living practice: it honored the multiplicity without requiring the reduction to a single tradition.**

THE NEW APOSTOLIC REFORMATION

The Traveling Preachers — Apostles, Prophets, and Spiritual Warfare

WHAT THE NEW APOSTOLIC REFORMATION IS

Emerged: 1990s • Associated academics: C. Peter Wagner • Key figures: Lou Engle, Cindy Jacobs

The New Apostolic Reformation (NAR) is a contemporary Evangelical movement identified and named by missiologist C. Peter Wagner of Fuller Theological Seminary in the 1990s. It is not a single denomination but a network of related movements and ministries that share a common theological framework centered on the belief that God is restoring the five-fold ministry offices of the early church: Apostles, Prophets, Evangelists, Pastors, and Teachers (Ephesians 4:11-13).

Modern Apostles — the movement's most distinctive claim — are understood to have the same authority as the biblical apostles: direct divine revelation, the authority to establish and oversee churches and movements, and the ability to perform signs and wonders. Prophets receive direct messages from God and deliver them to individuals, churches, cities, and nations. The authority of these offices is understood as direct and supernatural — not derived from institutional position but from divine appointment.

This is likely the traveling preacher movement you described — NAR ministers hold large-scale events (The Call, Azusa Now, and similar gatherings) characterized by extended worship, prophetic declarations, healing prayer, and spiritual warfare. These events can draw hundreds of thousands of participants.

SPIRITUAL WARFARE THEOLOGY

The NAR's most distinctive theological contribution is its highly developed spiritual warfare framework — the teaching that demonic beings (territorial spirits) control specific geographic territories and that these spirits must be displaced through strategic prayer, prophetic declarations, and coordinated spiritual action before communities, cities, and nations can experience genuine transformation.

The Seven Mountains of Culture — business, government, media, arts and entertainment, education, family, and religion — are the domains that NAR theology teaches must be occupied by committed Christians for Christ's kingdom to be established on earth. This framework, sometimes called Dominionism or Kingdom Now theology, has significant political implications and has been connected to political movements in the United States and globally.

The prayer strategies associated with NAR spiritual warfare — 24/7 prayer rooms, prayer walks through cities, coordinated prayer against specific spiritual entities over geographic areas — represent a sophisticated understanding of the power of focused collective intention, though directed through a framework of combat and territorial control rather than healing and restoration.

♦ **HALIGRIC LENS:** The NAR correctly identified that focused collective intention affects the field of shared reality — this is the quantum coherence that the Hundredth Monkey Effect documents and that ceremony in every indigenous tradition enacts. What the NAR did with this recognition — casting it in the framework of cosmic warfare, territorial demonic control, and the Seven Mountains dominion — channeled real power through a lens of combat and control rather than harmony and restoration. The prayer is real. The framework around it shapes what it produces.

UNITY CHURCH AND RELIGIOUS SCIENCE

New Thought in Church Form — Haligricity's Philosophical Ancestors

Unity and Religious Science are the institutional expressions of the New Thought movement — they represent what happens when the philosophy that consciousness creates reality, that affirmative prayer works, and that the divine lives within every person is organized into a community with Sunday services, music, pastoral care, and a congregation. They are the closest thing to a Haligricity church that currently exists.

UNITY CHURCH — Charles and Myrtle Fillmore

Founded: 1889, Kansas City, Missouri • Headquarters: Unity Village, Missouri

Charles Fillmore and Myrtle Page met in Kansas City in the 1880s. Myrtle was suffering from tuberculosis and attended a New Thought lecture where she heard the phrase 'I am a child of God and therefore I do not inherit sickness.' She took this statement as a literal truth, repeated it in prayer and meditation over the following two years, and recovered completely from tuberculosis. Her healing became the foundation event of Unity.

Charles, initially skeptical, began his own investigation and found that the principles that had healed Myrtle were consistent with the New Testament when read metaphysically — when the words of Jesus were understood as descriptions of universal spiritual laws rather than theological propositions about a specific historical figure. The two founded the Unity Society of Practical Christianity in 1889.

Unity theology teaches that God is Absolute Good, present everywhere, including within every human being. Jesus Christ is understood as the pattern for human development — the Christ consciousness that Jesus embodied is the divine potential within every person. Sin is understood as missing the mark — error in thinking that produces suffering — not as a moral transgression requiring divine punishment. Prayer is affirmative — spoken to the God within, affirming truth rather than petitioning an external authority.

The Daily Word — Unity's devotional publication — is one of the most widely distributed spiritual publications in the world, reaching millions of readers across denominational boundaries. Many people who would not identify as Unity members read the Daily Word as part of their daily spiritual practice.

❖ **HALIGRIC LENS:** Myrtle Fillmore's healing is a documented example of what Haligrity teaches about the relationship between inner recognition and physical reality. She did not petition an external God for healing. She recognized a truth about her own nature — that as a child of the divine she did not inherit sickness — and held that recognition consistently until her body reflected it. This is the Observer Effect operating through sustained conscious intention. It is Heka. It is Haligrity.

RELIGIOUS SCIENCE — Ernest Holmes

Founded: 1927 • Centers for Spiritual Living: global network • Key text: The Science of Mind (1926)

Ernest Holmes was a self-educated New Thought philosopher who published *The Science of Mind* in 1926 — one of the most comprehensive systematic presentations of New Thought philosophy ever written. Holmes drew from Ralph Waldo Emerson, Christian Science, Theosophy, Vedanta, and his own extensive study of comparative religion and philosophy to construct a unified metaphysical system he called Religious Science.

Holmes's central principle is the Law of Mind in Action — the teaching that mind (consciousness) is the fundamental reality, that the Universe is a mental system, that thoughts held consistently in mind produce corresponding conditions in the physical world, and that the spiritual practitioner's role is to treat — to affirm the truth of spiritual perfection until that truth is reflected in the apparent condition.

Spiritual Mind Treatment — the specific form of affirmative prayer taught in Religious Science — has a five-step structure: Recognition (God is), Unification (I am one with God), Realization (therefore this specific truth is already spiritually established), Thanksgiving (gratitude for the truth already recognized), and Release (letting go into the law). This structure is taught to every Religious Science practitioner and is the primary tool of the tradition.

❖ **HALIGRIC LENS:** *The Science of Mind's* Law of Mind in Action is the most systematically developed Western philosophical account of what the Observer Effect, the DNA Phantom Effect, and the Hundredth Monkey Effect scientifically document — that consciousness affects material reality through a mechanism that is not yet fully understood but is consistently observable. Holmes arrived at this conclusion through philosophy and comparative religion decades before quantum physics began to confirm it. Haligrity stands in this lineage directly — and names it more completely.

THE WORD OF FAITH / PROSPERITY GOSPEL

The Mechanism Is Real — The Theology Distorts It

ORIGINS — Kenneth Hagin and the Rhema Tradition

Emerged: 1950s-1970s • Key figures: Kenneth Hagin, Kenneth Copeland, Creflo Dollar, Benny Hinn, Joel Osteen

The Word of Faith movement traces primarily to Kenneth Hagin (1917-2003) of Tulsa, Oklahoma, who claimed to have had multiple visions of Jesus and who developed the theological framework that came to define the movement. Hagin drew heavily from E.W. Kenyon, a New England preacher who had been influenced by New Thought and Christian Science in the late 19th century — a lineage that Hagin did not always acknowledge.

The core Word of Faith principles are: faith is a force (not merely a disposition but a literal spiritual force that moves in the realm of the spirit), words are containers of faith (spoken words release or block the spiritual force of faith), and confession produces possession (speaking a desired outcome with faith causes it to manifest in physical reality). Health and financial prosperity are the covenant rights of the believer — provisions already purchased by Christ's atonement and available through faith confession.

The movement spread globally through Hagin's Rhema Bible Training College and through his most prominent student, Kenneth Copeland, who built the largest Word of Faith ministry empire. From Copeland the teaching spread through Creflo Dollar, Benny Hinn, Joyce Meyer, and eventually — in a more polished, psychologically accessible form — through Joel Osteen, whose Lakewood Church in Houston is the largest congregation in America.

THE MECHANISM IS REAL

The Word of Faith tradition identified something genuine. The relationship between inner state and outer circumstance is real. The power of spoken affirmation to reshape consciousness and thereby affect material experience is real. The New Thought lineage from which the tradition draws — whether acknowledged or not — documented this mechanism with philosophical rigor. Quantum physics, psychoneuroimmunology, and the neuroscience of neuroplasticity have begun to provide biological mechanisms for what the tradition describes spiritually.

The problem is not the mechanism. The problem is the theological framework placed around it. When the mechanism is attributed to faith in an external God whose covenant provisions can be released through specific verbal formulas, the practitioner who does not manifest the desired result has only one explanation available:

insufficient faith. They have failed. They have not believed correctly enough. The God who should have delivered has not — because they were not worthy.

This is the precise inversion of the mechanism's actual operation. The inner state that produces change in material reality is not desperate striving for a result that an external God may or may not provide. It is the settled recognition — available now, not earned — that the desired reality is already true at the level of consciousness. The framework of external divine provision, faith as technique, and tithing as the price of prosperity corrupts the mechanism precisely by keeping the practitioner's awareness focused outward on the God who is withholding rather than inward on the recognition that is already complete.

*"Name it and claim it. Blab it and grab it." — Critical shorthand
for Word of Faith teaching*

*"The prosperity gospel has killed more people than cancer. It
has destroyed more finances than gambling. It has ruined more
marriages than adultery. It has devastated more spiritual lives
than atheism." — John Piper (Reformed theologian critique
from within Christianity)*

♦ **HALIGRIC LENS:** Haligrity holds the mechanism — the creative power of conscious intention, spoken with the full alignment of feeling, thinking, speaking, and doing — without the external-God framework that makes it extractive. The Varessence is not a formula for getting God to deliver. It is a technology for aligning the whole self with the recognition of what is already true. The difference is not cosmetic. It is the difference between a person who believes they are worthy of the divine's provision and a person who knows they are the divine's expression.

THE HALIGRIC SYNTHESIS

What Each Tradition Carries

The Haligric practitioner does not dismiss any of the traditions covered in this document or in the two preceding Christianity documents. Each carries something real — something that emerged because people needed it, because they were searching for the divine with the tools and frameworks available to them in their specific historical and cultural context.

TRADITION	WHAT IT CARRIES	WHAT IT OBSCURES
Jehovah's Witnesses	Devotion, community, scriptural rigor	Self-authority shunning as control
Unitarian Universalism	Free search, synthesis, human dignity	Sometimes lacks depth of practice
New Apostolic Reformation	Collective intention, prophetic voice	Combat framework, territorial control
Unity Church	Affirmative prayer, healing recognition	Sometimes overly positive
Religious Science	Systematic metaphysics, treatment practice	Can become overly intellectual
Word of Faith	The mechanism — spoken word and intention	External God, extraction, blame

❖ **HALIGRIC LENS:** The Haligric practitioner who has moved through or alongside any of these traditions carries something from each one — the devotion of the Witnesses without the shunning, the free search of the UU without the formlessness, the collective intention of the NAR without the warfare, the affirmative prayer of Unity without the toxic positivity, the systematic metaphysics of Religious Science without the intellectualism, the spoken creative power of Word of Faith without the extraction. Haligrity is what you find when you take everything these traditions identified and strip away everything they placed around it that kept people from finding what they were actually looking for.

This document is part of the Haligricity Personal Reading Series.